



school cricket, Thakuri expressed confidence in the burgeoning talent pool. "In our time, few considered cricket a viable career option, but attitudes have shifted. With each success of the national team, more youngsters are embracing the sport seriously."

Sompal Kami, one of the senior-most members of the team, brings a wealth of experience as a fast-bowling all-rounder. A part of Nepal's 2014 World T20 squad that achieved notable victories, beating Hong Kong and Afghanistan, Kami has imparted his knowledge gained from

stalwarts such as Khadka and Shakti Gauchan to the current crop of players. "Back then, the struggles were a lot. The salaries were low and there was no contract system. We have come a long way. Our salaries have increased, and most importantly, we now have a contract system, which is a huge thing for us," Kami said. "It feels nice when people bank on our abilities, and that has happened because our game has improved."

Nepal underwent a period of coaching changes, affecting the team's planning. However, since Desai assumed leadership last year, there has been a notable upward trajectory. "We have played under several coaches, but Monty sir has given the team a new direction and has brought the players together," Kami said. "The result is showing."

Having taken over from former India

Experienced head: Monty Desai was appointed head coach of Nepal in February 2023. Desai has had coaching experience with Afghanistan, Canada, West Indies, and IPL teams such as Rajasthan Royals and the now-defunct Gujarat Lions.

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international Manoj Prabhakar, Desai had an arduous task at hand. When he joined the team in February 2023, the Associate Member Nation needed 11 wins from 12 games in the World Cup Super League 2 points table. Only a miracle could have earned Nepal a spot in the ODI World Cup Qualifier in Zimbabwe.

Yet, drawing from his extensive experience with IPL franchises and the West Indies team, Desai instilled confidence in the players, leading to a remarkable turnaround. Nepal's unexpected surge into the Qualifiers and participation in the 2023 Asia

« I am lucky to be representing the country in yet another T20 World Cup.

– Nepal all-rounder Gulshan Jha »

